charm. I told him I was starting to get more fan mail than I could handle and said: “Look, you don’t have to do this if you don’t want to, but you could really help me; I’ve got a heck of a problem with this fan mail, mailing out autographed pictures and so forth; what would you say if I got you a secretary’s pass and a regular salary at the studio and you came in every day to pick up the mail, look it over, order the pictures, and so forth.”

Well, Jack jumped at it. It was a real job, it gave him self-respect, and he did a great job at it.

One day he showed me a letter from a young woman who had written that she was dying and wanted a photo of me before she did.

I thought it was a story invented by someone who believed that’s what it took to get an autographed picture. Jack urged me to sign the picture anyhow and I did. About ten days later, I got a letter from a nurse who told me that the woman, who was named Mary, had died with my picture in her hands and that it had made her very happy to have it.

Jack never said “I told you so.”

He kept on handling the fan mail for me until, at the age of fifty-eight, his heart finally gave out and he died in the home in California that he had come to love.

When he died so young, I blamed it at first on his problem with alcohol. Now I think his heart may have finally failed because of smoking. I’d always thought of Jack as a three-pack, one-match-a-day man: In the morning he’d use one match to light his first cigarette of the day, and from then on, he’d light the next one from the old one.

The home he loved in California and his job at the studio may have helped him finally lick the curse that had hounded him so long. I was in the East on an errand for the motion picture industry when my mother called and told me that he had died. During the call, she told of finding Jack one night standing in the house, looking out the window, and he